

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr manish bhalla

Address: 151 Collingwood Road Sutton SM1 2QW

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I object to the proposed planning application on the following grounds:

The National Planning Policy Framework (December 2024) requires developments to promote social interaction and healthy communities, and to ensure they do not undermine community cohesion (paras 96 and related). This should be considered. This proposal risks the opposite.

The borough needs neutral, multi-use community spaces (e.g. halls, youth centres, recreational venues) that serve residents of all backgrounds and faiths equally, rather than a specialised facility for one group. Prioritising shared infrastructure would better foster genuine unity.

The borough already has multiple functional/operational mosques in operation.

This appears significantly disproportionate relative to the local Muslim population (based on census/demographic data).

At the same time, other faith groups - with similar proportion of population - have no dedicated place of worship at all.

Further provision for one group raises serious concerns about fairness, equitable resource allocation, and balanced treatment of all faith communities.

A fact-finding exercise should be done to check proportion of local population of different faiths and how many places of worship already exist before approving any new ones.

UK policy has moved away from failed multiculturalism towards active integration and assimilation. The Casey Review (2016) warned of "parallel lives," residential clustering, and segregation risks in some communities.

Additional large or concentrated faith facilities frequently become focal points that encourage clustering, leading within a few years to enclaves with:

- reduced everyday mixing between groups
- diminished shared British identity
- the very ghettoisation the Review cautioned against.

An example is in nearby Morden where a big mosque has seen local demography change in last decade.

In our beautiful borough, already experiencing demographic pressures and change, approving another mosque is likely to entrench separation rather than build inclusive cohesion - directly contrary to NPPF goals for unified, integrated places.

References -

1. National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) - December 2024

- *Official GOV.UK page*: <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/national-planning-policy-framework--2>

- *Direct PDF (full document)*:

https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/67aaf8f3b41f783cca46251/NPPF_December_2024.pdf (published 12 December 2024)

Relevant section:

Paragraph 96 states:

"Planning policies and decisions should aim to achieve healthy, inclusive and safe places which:

a) promote social interaction, including opportunities for meetings between people who might not otherwise come into contact with each other...

b) are safe and accessible, so that crime and disorder, and the fear of crime, do not undermine the quality of life or *community cohesion*...

c) enable and support healthy lives..."

Paragraph 98 also covers community facilities (explicitly including "places of worship") and requires planning to "plan positively for the provision and use of shared spaces, community facilities... to enhance the sustainability of communities" and "take into account... the delivery of local strategies to improve... social and cultural well-being for *all sections of the community*."

2. Casey Review (2016) - "The Casey Review: a review into opportunity and integration"

- *Official GOV.UK page*: <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/the-casey-review-a-review-into-opportunity-and-integration>

- *Direct PDF (full 200+ page report)*:

https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/5a80c4fded915d74e6230579/The_Casey_Review_Report.pdf (published 5 December 2016 by Dame Louise Casey)

The review explicitly warns about "parallel lives", residential clustering, segregation risks, and how concentrated faith facilities (especially large mosques) can accelerate enclave formation and reduce everyday mixing. Key relevant sections include Chapters 7-8 (on segregation and religion), Chapter 9 (concentrations of Muslim/Pakistani communities), and Annex A (legacy of "parallel lives" from earlier reports). It directly supports your points on integration over multiculturalism and the risks of further specialised facilities.

3. Latest Census - Religion in Sutton Borough (2021 Census)

This is the most recent official data (2021; the next full census is 2031).

*Total usual residents in Sutton: **209,602*

Full religion breakdown (2021):

Religion	Number	Percentage
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Christian	95,983	45.8%
No religion	67,779	32.3%
Muslim	14,722	7.0%
Hindu	14,663	7.0%
Buddhist	1,814	0.9%
Other	1,249	0.6%
Jewish	407	0.2%
Sikh	449	0.2%
No answer	12,536	6.0%

Sources (official ONS data):

- Interactive ONS visualisation with % changes:

<https://www.ons.gov.uk/visualisations/censusareachanges/E09000029>

- Detailed numbers: ONS-derived tables (e.g., via citypopulation.de cross-reference)